



Part 1

1. Why is this important?

- Our eating and drinking choices impact our performance as workers, parents, friends, etc. They affect our energy levels, our ability to hold concentration for long periods and our mood.
- Maybe you have noticed this with some types of food? You crave them, then eat them even though you know before that you won't feel great afterwards.

2. And this is not just about too much food or the wrong kinds of foods. Ever felt **hangry**?

- If we don't eat frequently enough, our blood sugar levels drop which has a direct knock-on effect on our impulse control.
- This means you are more likely to snap at somebody unnecessarily or say something you later regret.
- It also means that when it comes to eventually satisfying your hunger that you may give in to the impulse to overeat. Ever put too much on your plate at that all you can eat buffet and left some behind?

3. The fuel for nutrition analogy is wrong...

- Fuel will keep your car running no matter what station you fill it at. But imagine filling up at an Esso garage meant you could skip traffic all day and that filling at Statoil meant you got stuck in the traffic – what would you choose?
- By feeling so busy with work we often fall into the trap of just looking at fuel as food. Unlike a car the type of fuel we choose matters to keep us feeling energetic and in good form.

4. Here's how our bodies turn different fuel into energy:

- Our body turns just about everything we eat into glucose which provides our brains with energy to help us keep focused. Low glucose levels mean low energy levels resulting in a tough time concentrating and ignoring a rumbling stomach.





5. Our bodies process different foods at different speeds. Why is this important from a health, wellness and performance perspective?

- Some foods release their glucose quickly like bread, pasta, cereal and soft drinks. This means a quick burst of energy but then a slump. This is why eating a waffle gives you approximately 20 minutes of alertness followed by a crash.
- On the other extreme, foods that are high in fat but that also contain some protein like deep fried chicken wings provide more sustained energy. However, there is a big **caveat** with these foods. They also require our digestive system to work harder meaning less oxygen to the brain and a groggier feeling. Just think back to the last heavy lunch which you ate and the food coma that afternoon.

Part 2

1. Glycaemic index – use it wisely to know the foods that give a good, steady and lengthy release of energy.

- Each food is given a rating between 1 and 100. It tells how they compare to pure glucose which is 100 on the scale.
- Foods which have a low number release glucose into your bloodstream gradually.
- This is ideal because a steady release of glucose prevents fluctuations in blood sugar. We want this, as a steady of glucose helps sustain our mental focus.

2. What foods are high on the glycaemic index?

- A baguette is 95, corn flakes are 93 and a baked potato is 85. Short grain white rice has a rating of 72 and when consuming things like this in the evening it can actually have a sedative effect which is maybe not a bad thing as you are preparing for sleep soon anyway.
- Whole wheat pasta has a score of 37 while white pasta is 45. Brown rice has a GI of 55 and may actually help you feel fuller with a lesser amount than white rice. Its greater fibre content is more than likely the reason behind this more satiating effect of brown rice.
- It also means that when it comes to eventually satisfying your hunger that you may give in to the impulse to overeat. Ever put too much on your plate at that all-you-can-eat buffet and left some behind?





3. What foods are **low** on the glycaemic index?

- Here are some examples of protein rich foods on the low end of the index. Hummus is 6, peanuts are 7, others that are low are green vegetables, beans, lentils, peaches, etc. These foods tend to keep you fuller for longer.
- A caveat when it comes to nuts is to split a larger bag into smaller sachets so you just snack on one sachet and don't have a steady snacking scenario on the large bag until they are all gone.
- Click [here](#) for an awesome breakdown of the glycaemic index values for the vast majority of foods which we consume.

4. Lastly, a note on **glycaemic load**:

- The glycaemic index is a great guideline. However it should not be used in isolation or we won't get the whole picture. The index measures the effect of a small amount of food, usually 50 grams of carbohydrates, over a period of two hours.
- The glycaemic load (GL) takes into account the GI rating of a particular food **and** really importantly it also accounts for the portion size. The rationale is that a small amount of high-GI food would have the same effect on the body as a larger amount of low-GI food. This is why I would encourage some white potato or rice at dinner during a drop-a-jean-size type of challenge.
- The GL is calculated by taking the GI of a food, multiplying it by the amount of carbohydrates in grams and dividing that number by 100. Understanding the GL is useful for diabetics and others needing to monitor the quality and quantity of food that they eat.

Part 3

1. **Lunch tip** – eat for performance and not a long life.

- We all have a good idea of the kind of foods which are good for us and which aren't. However common sense doesn't always mean common practice.
- We will often have this little demon on our left shoulder saying: *"Go for the sweet thing, you deserve it! Sure, one more won't hurt!"* Let's learn to talk back to this little demon.
- By focusing on eating in a way that enables you to get an important work or personal task done in the afternoon you will be more likely to choose good fuel at lunch time.





Remember that fatty meal will leave you groggy and that too big a bowl of pasta will send you into a food coma.

- A lovely salad niçoise, however, could provide you with the optimal level of energy to get that task done effectively with no grogginess.
- Eating for a longer life is too abstract to motivate us to want to eat better in the short term.

2. Some tips for eating better at work – make unhealthy eating more difficult.

- A study from **Cornell University** showed participants ate over twice as many sweets when they were in a transparent box versus one you could not see through. The other element of the study was a proximity test. When the sweets were on the desk versus two metres away then 1.8 times as many sweets were consumed.
- This is empowering as it means that if we stop bringing rubbish food into our homes and workplaces that we are less likely to go to the effort of eating it. Also, we can put chocolate into the back shelves instead of leaving it on the counter to reduce impulsive behaviour.

3. Make healthy eating easier.

- Try bringing fruit, a yogurt or some baby carrots into work instead. This may not seem immediately tempting but believe me that your taste buds will change. As you start to cut back on the processed sweet treats these fruit and other healthy snacks become more attractive and satisfying.
- Don't just bring them in and leave them at the bottom of your bag. The same rule works with visibility as the sweets mentioned above. Leave them in your line of vision to remind you of the healthy, flavoursome option awaiting you on your 11.00am break.
- I want to mention another study similar to one mentioned above, however I feel this point is worth reiterating so will demonstrate it again:
- A different **Cornell University study** took photographs of 200 American kitchens. The goal of the study was to see if the foods visible on kitchen counter could predict the weight of a person living in the home. And indeed, what they found is that people who had breakfast cereals sitting on their counters weighed 20-lbs more than those who didn't. On the other hand, those who had a fruit bowl out in the open weighed nearly 13-lbs less. To me, that seems like a pretty remarkable finding. Could there be a healthy habit change you could make based on this finding?
- We often spend hard earned money on nice fruit and vegetables only to put them in the back of a dark cupboard. Let's make them the most visible and the subject of our focus.





Part 4

1. A good rule of thumb.

- When eating for top metal performance and a healthy body, lean protein like grilled chicken or salmon as well as carbs that are low on the glycaemic index works well.
- Here's that awesome glycaemic index reference of foods again – click [here](#).
- If you're looking for vegetarian options high in protein, here are some must haves in your cupboard. Tofu, edamame, lentils, chickpeas, beans (kidney, black, pinto, etc.), soya, amaranth, quinoa, cottage cheese and Greek yogurt and a lot more.
- For a list of 49 protein high options for vegans and vegetarians along with three recipes for each option make sure to check out this great article – click [here](#).

2. Importance of fruit and vegetables and getting the ratio right.

- Many sources are now saying we should be upping our portions of fruit and vegetables to 7 per day which is up from the previously recommended 5 per day.
- When people are told to eat more fruits and vegetables, they often respond by simply eating more fruits. At face value that's not a bad thing. However many fruit are packed with calories and fructose. Vegetables on the other hand provide a mass of fibre and have limited impact on your blood sugar and therefore on your insulin levels.
- Avocado, kale, chard and lettuce are all very low on the GI. Here are some other very low options – click [here](#).
- Some fruits have surprisingly low calories as long as you don't add further sugar. Strawberries, blueberries, black currants and raspberries all do respectively well.
- An added benefit to upping vegetables over fruit is that it can have a positive effect on our waist line. A large banana has 120 calories versus a large carrot with 30 calories or a generous portion of broccoli – also about 30 calories.
- An important note on dry fruit. The drying process concentrates calories. 100g of fresh mango has 60 calories whereas 100g of dried mango has 314 calories.

3. What counts as a portion of fruit and vegetables?

- On the vegetable front a portion would count as 2 broccoli spears, 3 heaped tablespoons of cooked carrots or 7 cherry tomatoes. Same rules apply for tinned vegetables – try go for cans with no added salt or sugar.





- For fruit, 2 plums or satsumas count as a portion, 1 medium-size banana or orange counts as one, half a grapefruit, 30g of raisins to give you some examples.
- More in-depth information on this can be found [here](#).

4. A note on juices and smoothies.

- 3 small oranges have 135 calories, 33 grams of carbohydrate and 7 grams of fibre. A small 10-ounce glass of juice has 140 calories, 32 grams of carbohydrate and **zero** grams of fibre. Remember that juicing removes the skin and pulp which are great fibre sources. Fibre is important for digestive health and regular bowel movements.
- Smoothies can retain fibre when the whole fruit is used. Just beware the concentration of sugar in these as they often contain a lot of juice and large amounts of fruit in one serving. Yogurts and dairy are also often added which also adds to the calories count. They can be healthy if you monitor portions (easier with homemade rather than store bought) and consume as an occasional treat and not as a daily staple of your diet.

Part 5

1. We all know what good food is – I mean you don't need me to point out there's a big difference between an apple and apple pie.

- Eating healthily is not always easy due to time constraints and our emotional relationship with food.
- Do not allow these factors to become an excuse not to improve.
- Here are two tell-tale signs that you are an excuse maker and not taking ownership:

"I really want to get in better shape but... *INSERT SOB STORY HERE.*"

"Oh you see it's so easy for you cause... *INSERT RESENTFUL STATEMENT HERE.*"





2. Plan to succeed.

- We're much more likely to choose lower calorie, lower salt and more wholesome meals when choosing a meal for 3 months in the future (a wedding for example) versus when we're out for an evening meal with an old pal from college.
- When ordering for the present, we are more likely to pursue immediate gratification.
- How can we apply this to the working day? Use a cooler bag. The night before, put some chopped carrots, cucumber, grapes, cherry tomatoes, boiled eggs, etc. in a tupperware container and then into your cooler bag for work. Snack these during the workday.
- When going out for an evening meal, pick your option earlier in the day. This has the added benefit of freeing you up to be more social during the meal. This can also apply to a team lunch-time take-away at work – check out their menu and decide in advance.

3. Other helpful hints.

- Focus on achieving a positive outcome rather than avoiding a negative one. This is better for your mental health. An easy start is healthy snacking with nuts, fruit or vegetables. This helps keep steady energy levels and as you will not be starving at meal time you may choose less counterproductive meals.
- Diets tend to focus on depriving ourselves whereas this approach focuses on nourishing our bodies.
- **Do not** put back lunch time for fear of losing workflow. The afternoon energy dip will come regardless – it's natural. It will be harder to recover after that late lunch and it puts back everything else to later in the day including dinner and some of us do not sleep as well after a late dinner.
- If you're always exhausted after lunch, a coffee is ok. Just try to avoid the caffeinated version after 14.00.

